

MP3 Players

After integrating FM tuners and picture viewers, some high-end models have already moved to movie playback capabilities.

The Creative Zen Portable Media Center is one such example. It can play music (mp3, and wma, wav), video (avi, mpeg, mp2v, mpeg2), photos (jpeg) and Microsoft Recorded TV Show files (.dvr-ms).

Using Windows Media Player 10, this device can display large JPEG files, which is not possible otherwise. You have the option to either view the movie on the device screen or connect it to a TV via the video and line-out cables.

A text viewer and schedule option are other interesting features added into MP3 players recently—these let you read important notes and lyrics, and schedule FM recordings. The on-board screens can display as many as 2,60,000 colours, which is needed for better movie play-

back and image viewing. All this is here but not widely available. However, these features will get incorporated into more players once more vendors adopt them.

Do Remember

❑ Avoid excessive mechanical pressure on a portable player. This will prevent damage to sensitive parts such as the screen and the internal hard disk..

❑ Use good quality batteries of reputed brands, especially if you are using rechargeable batteries. Inferior quality batteries can leak inside the player and render it useless.

❑ Check for earphones. Bad quality earphones will destroy your listening experience and also cause discomfort. If you have a player that is of robust build quality, but has poor quality earphones, go for another pair of earphones which are more comfortable.

❑ If you want to use your flash



Buying Tips

✓ Flash based MP3 are good alternatives for thumb drives, for they can be easily synced and can double as MP3 players.

✓ Hard drive based MP3 players are best if you wish to carry your entire music collection with you

✓ Hard drive based mp3 player are bigger in size than flash based and therefore it makes more sense for those travelling short distance and needs just few hours worth music, to buy flash-based player

✓ Check out the battery requirements before buying a portable player. Batteries will add to the running cost of the player. Many models come with built-in rechargeable

batteries, opt for these instead.

✓ Buy a player which can house external memory cards as well, this way you can expand its storage space when you need to.

✓ Try and avoid players with proprietary USB cables, there are costlier and not as easily available as a standard USB cable

✓ Check the access time of the hard drive based mp3 players. If you find it takes too long to jump from one song to another just get flash based player.

✓ Make sure the software bundled with the player has no issue with your OS. Also see that it can be used as external hard drive to carry data other than MP3

Ready Reckoner



Low-end

You Need

To carry enough music for a few hours of listening

Look for

A Flash-based player with at least 128 MB memory



Mid-end

You Need

to carry music around without burning a hole in your pocket

Look for

A hard drive-based player with at least 5 GB storage



High-end

You Need

To carry your music around with no concern towards the budget

Look for

A hard drive based player with at least 20 GB of storage

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drive portable audio player as more of a storage solution than a music player, go for a solution that lets you use the disk as a storage option even when the battery is down. If you do want to listen to music, just plug in a battery and your music player is ready.

Facts

❑ Some hard-drive-based players heat up after prolonged use. It is therefore necessary to have enough inbuilt memory, so as to reduce disk spin.

❑ In a flash-based player, the backlight is the major consumer of battery power.

❑ Hard drive-based portable digital players may heat up after prolonged use. Ensure that the hard drive spin is reduced by getting a player that has considerable cache memory.

❑ Check for power saving options on a flash-based player. LCD displays and FM tuners absorb more power than normal music listening. Make sure that there are options to control the contrast of the LCD backlight, how much time should it remain on etc.